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Women petrified: how and when women turn to stone from Shakespeare to Byatt

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ABSTRACT
Dr Alice Langley explores a range of texts in which women petrify – turning to stone – and explores their petrification as a result of the shaming male gaze. Langley uses Mikhail Bakhtin's theory of the grotesque body to frame her textual analysis; it is the anxious pressure from the male characters analysed, including Leontes from Shakespeare's *The Winter's Tale*, and Pygmalion, both in Ovid and Madeline Miller's retelling, that seals and therefore silences the most problematic of female orifices – the mouth.

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Petrified women: why women turn to stone from Ovid to Byatt

In exploring why women petrify in literature, this work considers shame, often caused by the male gaze, grief, and the menopause, comparing and analysing renowned instances of women transforming to stone that are rarely considered together. These include Hermione from William Shakespeare's *The Winter's Tale* (1611); Rita from Lucy Wood's contemporary short story 'Countless Stones' (2012) and Ines from 'The Stone Woman' by A.S. Byatt (2003). In tracing the origins of female petrification and some of the best-known cases, this essay also delves into Ovid's *Pygmalion* and Madeline Miller's 2013 retelling, *Galatea*. The precis of this work is that the male gaze causes female petrification until, like Byatt's protagonist Ines, ageing offers freedom in the form of invisibility from the fertility-seeking control of the male gaze, demonstrating how women are liberated by the menopause to transform in a joyful, autonomous way.

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Ovid's *Metamorphoses* and the actual act of turning to stone (or animating and then re-petrifying in Miller's response) is a linguistic touchstone – Melissa Haynes succinctly argues that it has become so reflexive to refer to this myth, or quote from some part of it that, 'it is impossible to account for every scholarly mention of Pygmalion'[1] in her discussion of art crossing into life and vice versa. Similarly, Shakespeare's Hermione is the subject of countless critical interpretations, frequently associated with Pygmalion and his animated creation. Uniquely, this essay posits similarities between multiple instances of women who turn to stone, and draws analogies between the often-cited Classical and Shakespearean work and more modern texts. The thread between the examples given here is that petrification occurs in response to male pressure, usually masculine humiliation, that leads the woman to choose petrification, constituting her removal from this sphere of existence. I use Mikhail Bakhtin's writings on Rabelais to inform this interpretation of their transformation, arguing that the two forms, the grotesque and the Classical, are the states that these women move between. Pregnancy, menstruation, and lactation are all attributed to the grotesque and, here, so is the female form is, 'fertility, growth, and a brimming-over abundance. […] the sphere of earth and body in their indissoluble unity'.[2] By turning to stone, women are subject to conformity and must deny the Carnivalesque 'liberation from […] the established order',[3] forced to acquiesce to the 'finished, completed man'[4] who, alarmed by the unstable ground on which female identity manifests, demands a rejection of transformation. Asserted by Rosi Braidotti as a nomadic body, one which is 'a threshold of transformations […] the site of multiple, complex, and potentially contradictory sets of experiences',[5] and the cause of a deep patriarchal unease, therefore the male perpetrators in these texts insist that women submit to their anxiety by petrifying and sealing off the bodily orifices, specifically the mouth, which Bakhtin highlights as being the most grotesque of all holes, related as it is to 'swallowing, this most ancient symbol of death and destruction'.[6] The male bodily precedent is set; anti-transformation, adhering to a patriarchal world in which the shifting, leaky, fertile female body is only welcome in its most sealed, sanitised, and above all *silent* form, as soon as 'the mouth speaks in excess, it disturbs [the aesthetic form's] beautiful curvature and creates an ugly crater'.[7] The diverse range of literature in this study is intentional, and includes instances where transformation situates itself within the genres of fantasy or magical realism; using a Bakhtinian lens to identify different shared features between the cause of petrification for these women will provoke further conversation from our wide open mouths.

In *So You've Been Publicly Shamed* (2015), Jon Ronson describes the trial of a sixteen-year-old girl called Lindsay Armstrong.[8] Lindsay was raped one evening on her way home. At her trial, the defence counsel, John Carruthers, had her hold up the underwear she was wearing that night. He insisted that she describe it, tell the courtroom that it is a thong, and read the lettering –

Little Devil – aloud. The rapist was sentenced to four years in a juvenile detention centre. Lindsay took a lethal overdose. Her parents found her in her room, with 'Bohemian Rhapsody' playing. The rapist was released two years later.

In Shakespeare's *The Winter's Tale*, Act 2, Scene 3, Hermione, the Queen of Sicilia and King Leontes' wife, is accused of bearing a bastard child by Polixenes, courtier and close friend of the royal family. Hermione reluctantly accepts her place in her husband's incorrect accusations of adultery, saying, 'My life stands in the level of your dreams, / Which I'll lay down' (3.2.78–9),[9] referencing Leontes' deluded conviction that she has had an affair with Polixenes. In that same scene, Paulina, a noblewoman and friend to Hermione, verifies Leontes' madness as he rejects his newborn baby. Paulina tells him that Hermione is 'no less honest / Than you are mad, which is enough, I'll warrant, / As this world goes, to pass for honest' (2.3.69–71).[10] Leontes refuses to directly address Paulina until the end of the scene and uses second person to speak *about* her rather than to her, which seems like an avoidance tactic. By Act 3, Scene 2, Hermione's trial scene, Leontes has had time to solidify his unreasonable accusations and commit to utterly refuting Hermione, even going so far as to claim that 'There is no truth at all i'th,' oracle' (3.2.137),[11] whose message reads, 'Hermione is chaste', and 'Polixenes blameless' (130).[12]

Both Lindsay and Hermione are women accused of sexual impropriety by a patriarchal society. Hermione's innocence is evidenced by multiple sources. Leontes' accusations become more and more convoluted until they are as ignorant and misplaced as blaming a woman wearing a thong for her own rape. In an interview, Linda, Lindsay's mother, said that there might be no physical proof that Lindsay's suicide is linked to her rape, but Linda knows that's why her daughter killed herself.[13] Lindsay had good grades in recent exams, was described by friends and family as 'outgoing'[14] and was considering a career as a lawyer. We will never know whether, had Lindsay not been raped, shamed in court, devastated by knowing the rapist would be released in four years, she would be alive today.

But we do know.

Ambiguity also surrounds Hermione's withdrawal from the action of *The Winter's Tale*. In his introduction to Arden's 2010 edition, John Pitcher writes:

> Everyone knows it ends with a statue that comes to life, but Shakespeare won't let us be fully sure what we have seen. Did Hermione die, and this is her reanimation? Or was she just hidden, waiting, numbed and dead to the world?[15]

Pitcher goes on to analyse Shakespeare's use of ghosts and spectres; in the scene following Paulina's announcement of Hermione's death, she appears to Antigonus in a dream, which 'proves, almost certainly […] that Hermione

is dead'.[16] The ghost's actions verify her death which means that, at some point, she petrifies, transmutes into a statue and remains in Paulina's chapel until she can be unveiled in Act 5, Scene 3, marvellously coming to life. Petrification is synonymous with her death as she is removed from the sphere of the grotesque, replete with its bodily functions (Hermione has just given birth, the most grotesque of all human endeavours), and she becomes a statue with an 'impenetrable surface that closes and limits the body as a separate and completed phenomenon'.[17] This petrification can and should be attributed to Leontes. Nothing indicates Hermione would turn to stone without her husband's accusations, her imprisonment which causes the death of her son, or the public denigration she is subject to.

Pitcher emphasises Leontes' delusions; he 'turns real bodies into figments of his imagination'.[18] Prior to this, Pitcher tells us that 'The statue is key to what happened in Leontes' mind […] The King had created a simulacrum of Hermione in his imagination, an idol of an unyielding stony lady elevated above him'.[19] This idol has two conflicting identities: the unattainable woman, and the adulterous one. Both of these perspectives are Leontes' and, combined with his Kingly authority, they allow him to publicly shame his wife. Additionally, the love and intense feeling the statue arouses in those who look at it 'is a sign that he [Leontes] has long been guilty of a special kind of idolatry, uxoriousness – placing the love of one's wife above God';[20] Leontes' obsessive, jealous 'love' is as responsible for Hermione's transformation as Lindsay's rapist is for her death. Both are acts of violation; Leontes betrays Hermione, and his variant of the male gaze, idolising and simultaneously jealous, coheres with that of a defence lawyer who creates a lens of implied temptation through which the courtroom was asked to view Lindsay. Both women's abusers destroyed their defences and walked away.

Suicide and petrification are how these women remove themselves from situations in which they are powerless and have been humiliated, faced with accusations which are as impossible to deny as they are unfounded. After legal proceedings which debase them, they take the only action left available to them. Both Hermione and Lindsay's transformations render them unavailable to the perpetrators of their shame. Their denial is inconsequential, and they have been effectively silenced by male authority which deliberately suppresses any argument; petrification becomes a literal representation of this silencing, the statue as Classical body with its impenetrable surface and closed, mute mouth. The placement of Hermione and Lindsay side by side is a deliberate and intentional indictment of the justice system, the consequences of shaming, and the full stop punched by their male perpetrators.

Shakespeare's early modern society was familiar with humorism (the medical model that saw health controlled by a series of 'humours') and the

grotesque body, which would be later theorised by Mikhail Bakhtin. Gail Kern Paster convincingly argues the connection between these concepts in Bakhtin's work:

> similarities between the humoral and grotesque bodies could not be coincidental, because the medieval culture Bakhtin reads in order to construct his grotesque bodily canon understood the body in humoral terms.[21]

Drawing on Norbert Elias's *The History of Manners* (1939) and the description of 'shame as a control mechanism of the civilizing process',[22] Paster correlates the suppression of humours to the awareness of shame as indirectly proportional. To further extrapolate this point, the suppression of humours can therefore be aligned with the creation of, or transformation to, the Bakhtinian Classical body; a body which is 'closed off, finished, a body all surface and no interior',[23] the body of a statue. Hermione's petrification seals the parts of her body that are thresholds and are therefore open to permeation by, for example, the penis of Polixenes. Though this unequivocally did not happen, her body has already transgressed into a site of grotesquery through her pregnancies, lactation, menstruation etc. and so the shaming gaze of Leontes has the dual effect of sealing her, mastering the leaky female body for the sake of the aforementioned 'civilizing process' and bringing her under his control. That he immediately regrets his actions is, indisputably, Leontes' problem.

Bakhtin was interested in the body as 'instrument of political critique',[24] which is frequently what rape victims are forced to become, silent representatives of change that is happening too slowly to save them.[25] Pitcher implicates the petrifying power of the male gaze in *The Winter's Tale*, writing that, 'Not even a supreme artist can restore the dead to life unless he has complete faith in something'.[26] Leontes *did* have complete faith in something and was willing to execute his wife and new-born child on this baseless and disproved dream. Leontes' punishment, to live alone with his guilt, lasts for seventeen years – fifteen more than that of Lindsay's rapist.

Having established the opposing forms, Classical and grotesque, and the censoring power of shame, both silencing and solidifying, I now consider other texts in which women undergo petrification and the relationship of that transformation with the actions or gaze of the men in their immediate vicinity. The male gaze as both idolising and shaming, sometimes both at once, is notoriously emblematised in Ovid's *Pygmalion*, a story which would have been 'ubiquitous in the Renaissance'.[27] Shakespeare aligns the story of Hermione and Leontes more closely with that of Pygmalion than its Ovidian narrator, Orpheus, whose own story of death-to-life culminates with the loss of Euridice, a tragedy again attributed to the male gaze. Orpheus's doubting glance, his moment of weakness, condemns him to an eternity without his love. In Ovid, Pygmalion, 'Sick of the vices with

which the female sex has been so richly endowed, he chose for a number of / years to remain unmarried' (10.244–245),[28] which seems like no great loss to womankind, until Venus animates Pygmalion's marble creation, and blesses their union with a daughter; the artist's vision is imbued with the miracle of life.

Madeline Miller's retelling, *Galatea*, paints a grotesque and unsympathetic portrait of Pygmalion, who wants the living Galatea to retain a statue-like silence, and removes their daughter, Paphos, from her care. Miller's Galatea has a voice, a direct and witty personality, and a selfhood which is denied the character in Ovid's version of the story (where she doesn't even have a name), the happy ending of which only works if we accept multiple kinds of misogyny and a problematic fetishisation of beauty. Using first-person narrative, Galatea relates how Pygmalion tells her 'again how well he had cared for me, dressing me in silks, draping me in flowers and jewels, and bringing me seashells and colored balls, praying to the goddess every night'.[29] This fetishistic adulation, initially coy as Pygmalion plays with her like a kitten, turns into more sinister irrefutable accusations and physical assault. When Pygmalion tells her he is carving another statue, a girl of ten, Galatea breaks free from the room where she is kept, drugged and alone, waiting for him to rape her, and lures Pygmalion into the ocean.

In Ovid's version, Venus' involvement in the transformation is underplayed and it is Pygmalion's art and skill that is credited with transformative powers. A transformation that occurs in *The Metamorphosis*, the transformation of the Propoetides, lewd women of Cyprus, to granite 'didn't take much of a change' because of their preternaturally hard natures (10.242).[30] As if these women are stone-turned-human, returning to their original form, whereas the softness – the womanly flesh of Galatea – was already there. Ovid tells us, 'The ivory gradually lost its hardness, softening, sinking, yielding beneath his sensitive fingers. / Imagine beeswax from Mount Hyméttus, softening under the rays of the sun; imagine it moulded by human thumbs […] each touch contributing value' (10.284–285).[31] Pygmalion's contribution and culpability as the male sculptor are weighed more heavily than the goddess Venus' as responsible for the statue's animation and, with this great power, comes great responsibility.

Natalie Haynes has highlighted the explicit involvement and devastation caused by the male gaze in the story of Orpheus and Eurydice, Ovid's framing device for *Pygmalion*:

> In terms of art and the masculine identity […] it's a story which is all about the power of male-created art, to save and ultimately to destroy a woman and at the same time the act of destruction is the literal male gaze, literally the moment where he turns and looks at a woman and she disappears before his eyes.[32]

Pygmalion is a story about the power of the male artist's gaze, within a story pertaining to its destructive potential. In the introduction to *The Winter's Tale*, Pitcher offers two explanations of the male gaze: that 'men risk idolizing women by transforming them into never-changing objects' and simultaneously that 'the beauty of Nature's working is manifest when seen through the eyes of love'.[33] However, in Orpheus' case, the eyes of love are lethal. The deadly beam of this gaze is exposed by Paulina in the final scene of *The Winter's Tale*, who tells Leontes not to 'shun her [Hermione, present in statue form] / Until you see her die again, for then / You kill her double' (5.3.104–6),[34] again implicating Leontes in Hermione's transformation whilst suggesting that her petrification was a kind of death. Leontes has now seen Hermione-the-statue move, almost breathe, but this is not a smooth reunion. Hermione doesn't say a word to Leontes, instead only addresses Perdita, her daughter. Hermione acts for her daughter, as Galatea does in Miller's retelling of Ovid's story, rather than for the men implicit in their destruction. If not for Paulina bringing Perdita to her, Hermione could have remained in her stony form forever, like Niobe, transformed by grief to a stone figure that weeps at the loss of her children.

In his comprehensively researched book *Tears, Liquids and Porous Bodies in Literature Across the Ages*, Norbert Lennartz writes that the:

> oxymoronic idea of a stone that sheds copious tears [Niobe] inspired some writers and artists to become new Pygmalions and to turn their shockingly porous women back into dry lifeless blocks of marble.[35]

This suggests that, whether idolising or humiliating, the male intention remains the same: to control the grotesque female body and satisfy their demand for female silence. Shakespeare demonstrates the force of the shaming male gaze in its capacity to petrify in Leontes; Ovid literalises the power of idolatry as Galatea turns to mortal woman. However, Miller subverts the transformation that is dependent on the male gaze in her retelling of Pygmalion's story. Galatea flees from Pygmalion, running into the sea. By taking ownership of her narrative, reclaiming her story, she undergoes a second transformation:

> At first I thought it was just the cold of the water. [Pygmalion has caught her, but she encircles him in her arms] which stiffened around him. […] Then it was in my legs too, and my belly and my chest, and no matter how he kicked, he could not haul us back to the air. He hit at me, but it was watery and weak and I felt nothing […] the coolness slid up my neck and bled the colour from my lips and cheeks. […] We fell through the currents and I thought of how the crabs would come for him, climbing over my pale shoulders. The ocean floor was sandy and soft as pillows. I settled into it and slept.[36]

The image Miller conjures is multifaceted; the pinioned man drowning on the ocean bed, held by the marble arms he took so much pride in. The

verb 'slept' gives hope that, one day, Galatea might wake and walk across the grey-white sand of the Mediterranean seabed, stone limbs cracking, marble flakes drifting away into the water to reveal the flesh beneath as she kicks bare feet in a flurry of bubbles to emerge on the shore and reunite with her daughter. This is the happy ending. After vengeance, the victim lives.

The correlation between suicide and petrification in my own short story, 'The Stone Finger',[37] is a way of acknowledging 'the difficulties in accurately representing trauma, and at the same time engag[ing] readers with the text emotionally'.[38] The statue in the story watches as a human girl grows up, from a cute, coat-bundled toddler to an eyeliner-sporting teenager and, finally, her adult self, returning to turn to stone and withdraw from the world in a space where a palimpsest of her past selves at various ages is imprinted on layers of time. Petrification rather than death allows for and encourages a subjective reading; perhaps like Galatea, the unnamed woman in the story is only asleep.

The sense of inevitability and deliberate placement of reader as powerless voyeur in 'The Stone Finger' is similar to Lucy Wood's short story, 'Countless Stones'. When expanding Ephraim Lessing's discussion of aesthetics, Winfried Menninghaus describes the tension in the two seemingly opposing states, that the statue's apparent simplicity, 'gives way – as if an infinitely variable, wavering image – to an open sequence of deconfiguration and reconfiguration'.[39] There is a repulsive simultaneity held within the petrified body, the state of being both alive and unalive at the same time. Wood's story opens with Rita, the protagonist, waking, and she can 'feel it',[40] the inexorable creep of petrification. She knows she is turning to stone. Despite having preparations to make prior to her transformation, when her ex-boyfriend, Danny, calls because his car won't start in the snow, Rita decides she can 'spare an hour'.[41] Wood's juxtaposition of realism – exes with broken cars that ask her to house viewings mid-snowstorm – with Rita's transformation, provides the oil-on-water combination of magical realism: the casual slide of the mundane with the extraordinary that prevents 'Countless Stones' having the escapist qualities of fantasy literature, and instead encourages a more everyday empathy with Rita's dismal existence. Wood has said when interviewed that, by skewing our perspective on the everyday, magical realism 'can more strongly evoke the beauty, the wonder and the strangeness that is already inherently there'.[42] This is a character who thinks about dyeing her hair but never does, is thirty-six and works reluctantly in a café that leaves a 'stale bread and onion'[43] smell in her hair. She and Danny still see one another for birthdays and, occasionally, he spends the night. This kind of prudish phrasing and close third-person point of view emphasise the distance Rita has cultivated between herself and her own life. She is existing in a reflection, behind a glass wall, and her turning to stone is an extension of the liminal space she occupies daily, motionless and frozen.

On the surface, 'Countless Stones' presents a straightforward metaphor, but there are misdirects and half-whispered clues. One is Rita's consideration of previous instances she has petrified:

> Rita had changed three times before and each time it had lasted less than a month. But you could never be sure. There was always the possibility that the next time it would be for much longer. After a while, somebody would let themselves in and turn off your heating, your boiler. They would tidy things up and sort out the post on the doormat. They would turn off your fridge.[44]

There are now two ideas inconsistent with the 'stuck' analogy. Firstly, this has happened to Rita before, which means that it has also *un*happened to Rita before. She returned to her human form. Secondly, we discover that Rita is not unique in her transformation from the informative, matter-of-fact second person – 'somebody would let themselves in and turn off your heating' – and then, when Rita eventually reaches the cliffs, there are 'fifteen stones there, but the number changed all the time. Some of them looked new, others were covered in lichen',[45] clarifying the prior hints that this phenomenon happens to numerous people and is both accepted and supported by the community. The story's sedate and ineluctable pace not only support Winfried Menninghaus's suggestion that the stone women (extrapolated from her 'classical aesthetics') attempt to 'inscribe both [birth and death], as it were, "at once and in an instant", upon the beautiful body'[46] but impresses upon the reader that Rita is already living this half-life, neither one thing nor the other, and petrification will barely impact her.

Rita's almost-final thoughts before she completely transforms are about Danny:

> She thought of Danny, and of the house they had been to see. Did she like the house? She felt confused when she thought of it. Was she meant to have liked the house or not? Did it matter? The snow blurred it all so she couldn't even remember where the house was. It was a relief, really. The whole thing was a relief. There was the house somewhere in the snow; there was the snow in Danny's hair.[47]

That he is so prevalent in the final moments before Rita's petrification highlights Danny's position in her consciousness, how he saturates her existence; he is thought of in relation to domesticity, to the stasis Rita lives. Rita approaches her petrification with the same weary resignation she applies to the rest of her life and, although she was petrifying when she woke up that morning, aware that she may have only hours before she reaches this point, her exhausted acceptance and surrender to, like Hermione, the male activity going on around her. We believe her when she says it is a relief to slip into stone, that she feels relief in no longer having the option of deciding but will, like the dead, be considered blameless for her inaction. Her

petrification literalises the half-living, but half-dead, state she occupies, responding to Danny's requests for help in the way of a wife or girlfriend, but unable to move beyond her current, immobile state with him of situationship. Danny has a pervasive, incapacitating presence throughout the story; but *did it matter?* With that question, Rita takes her stony leave, sighing her way into petrification for an indeterminate length of time.

'Countless Stones' draws upon the Cornish folklore of the merry maidens, young women turned to stone for dancing on a Sunday[48] and, although Wood deliberately sidesteps naming places, she has been clear that her 'ideas for stories were linked to the landscape that [she] knew best'[49] and, by association, Cornish folklore and mythos. The idea that hedonistic sabbath-dancing, wild abandon, and loose morals are linked to transformation is one which Rosemary Jackson explores in *Fantasy: The Literature of Subversion* (1981). She discusses metamorphosis and entropy, a state in which human beings become borderless, and cites Freud's desire for undifferentiation in *Beyond the Pleasure Principle*,[50] a state which resembles the transgression of thresholds and permeable boundaries described by Bakhtin. Jackson writes that modern fantasy makes 'explicit this attraction towards an entropic state' and that it is in the writings of Sade that the desire to push the 'human' beyond itself can be found most explicitly, to arrive 'at a point of absolute unity of self and other, subject and object, at a zero point of entropy',[51] in the way that Rita is one with life, death, stone. Jackson goes on to emphasise this convergence of chaos with fantastic transformation, referencing the Comte de Láutreamont (Isidore Lucien Ducasse) and his work *Les Chants de Maldoror*, in which:

> Maldoror celebrates his body's interchangeability with animal life and with inorganic matter. He has lived 'a half-century in the form of a shark', has been both swan and pig: 'A man, a stone, or a tree', he chants, 'is going to begin this fourth song'. Human, bird, beast and amphibian forms merge together in an assertion of instability, of 'this ambiguous plurality in myself'. Nothing is stable or unitary: the subject is multiple, metamorphic.[52]

This entropic ideal can only be achieved through transformation, and metamorphosis – *male* metamorphosis – which is presented as limit-breaking, and existing in a state of perpetual motion, suggested by Jackson as a preoccupation of fantasy literature from the eighteenth-century onwards. In contrast Rita's transformation, however fantastical, is the antithesis of disorder and entropy. In bed, before beginning her day, Rita makes a mental list of tasks to accomplish before she petrifies. When she goes down to the kitchen, 'she checked the fridge to see if there was anything in there that would go off if she was away a long time'.[53] The list of fridge items, including a single portion of lasagne, an old onion, and some cheese, is both a device to

emphasise Rita's solitude, and also unequivocally prevents us from placing her in the same category as Maldoror, who, before transforming into a shark, probably did not consider his house plants.

Female petrification in AS Byatt's 'The Stone Woman' occurs in an explosively entropic finale, providing a counterpoint to the male-induced, tragic transformations of Hermione, Galatea, and Rita, and creating a link to the Bakhtinian fantastic, a connection to the earth in all its grotesquery. The protagonist, Ines, begins petrifying after the death of her mother, although Byatt maintains a degree of ambiguity around whether Ines' petrification begins *because* of this death, or whether it is due to lifesaving surgery that corrects her gut, which had been 'twisted and gangrenous'.[54] The surgeon has reshaped her navel, but Ines mourns her lost one, 'the umbilical cord that had been a part of her and of her mother'.[55] The connection between them is irrefutably severed. Transformation does not hold itself accountable to only one traumatic or lifechanging occurrence. Multiple events in parallel might be equally responsible or inextricably linked. Ines' initial change is slow: 'One day she found a cluster of greenish-white crystals sprouting in her armpit … she felt their stony roots stirring under the skin surface, pulling at her muscles'.[56] Rita too feels her insides petrifying; her 'stomach was hardening from the inside outwards, in rings like an old tree growing and hardening'.[57] Ines is, 'surprised at the fatalism with which she had resigned herself to her transformation',[58] within which there is a parallel to Rita's quiet acceptance.

There are moments of the grotesque in Byatt's story which are not present in Wood's. For example, a breadknife slip results in:

> a spurt of hot blood from the wound […] She [Ines] watched the thick liquid run down the back of her hand […] where it touched the bread the bread went up in smoke, and where it touched the table it hissed and smoked and bored its hot way through the wood.[59]

and on, singeing the plastic floor. Ines is self-aware enough to realise that 'To turn to stone is a figure, however fantastic, for death. But to become molten lava, to contain a furnace?'[60] This is a moment when the liquids exuded from the leaky female body are dangerous, potentially lethal to bystanders and substantiating fears from male characters in the other texts; if the female body is not sealed, controlled, lava might come out. Ines eventually leaves for Iceland with the stonemason Thorsteinn Hallmundurrson, who she meets repairing 'a gaggle of stone women, in various states of disrepair' in a graveyard. Why? Because Iceland is 'a primal chaos of ice, stone silt, black sand, gold mud',[61] and the stony trolls of Scandinavian folklore provide another element of this story. Legendarily, trolls are 'shifting and changing, hard to pin down in the end, except perhaps by what they are not: human, normal, helpful'.[62]

Folkloric metatextuality is redolent within Byatt's story; there are Paracelsian echoes, including that of the elemental gnomes who are capable of manipulating stone as easily as water.[63] Ines' transformation to different elementals, embodying the earth and land, is reflected in the multiple threads within the story itself, manifold parts that show the plethora of the central character's memories and experience; the women who are confined to a single lithic form are petrified in a stasis of both life and death, but denied the generosity of Ines' petrification.

Rita submits to stasis, whereas Ines, who 'had supposed that to be petrified was to be motionless',[64] is told by Thorsteinn that he does not think she is a troll. He believes her to be a metamorphosis; when her transformation is nearly complete, Ines 'jigged a little, as though gathering momentum, and then began a dancing run into the blizzard',[65] giving herself over entirely to the elements in the Nordic wilds; the metamorphosis possesses a dual meaning including metamorphic rock and the shifting of tectonic plates and fire beneath the ground. Byatt's story is much more attuned to the aliveness of the inanimate and the celebratory shifting between multiple states represented by Maldoror's changeability, a chaotic, unconfined movement that is subject to no one's will but their own.

Rita and Ines' inner experiences also diverge. Whereas Rita could 'feel the disks in her back grating over one another, like an old gate opening over stones',[66] Ines:

> feels the roll of polished stone in a stony cup as she moved her pelvis and hips, raised her knees and swung her rigid arms. There was a delicious smoothness to these motions, a surprise after the accommodations she was used to making for the crumbling calcium of arthritic joints.[67]

The various elements of Byatt's story, which shift in and out of Icelandic mythology, are very different from Wood's. Not only is Byatt's story more than two thousand words longer and seems to deliberately eschew the singularity and focus of more modern short stories. *Diving Belles*, the collection from which 'Countless Stones' is taken, was published in 2012, when Wood was twenty-six; 'The Stone Woman' originally appeared in *The New Yorker* in 2003, at which time Byatt would have been seventy-seven. Although Ines' age is never made explicit, we can assume she is older than Rita's thirty-six years. Perhaps Ines' (presumably) post-menopausal body is more used to change and transformation.

Byatt's story therefore supports Victoria Smith's contention that 'The experience of living in a female body is marked by instability and change […] gestation, lactation, menopause, years in which you are one thing and then suddenly are not'.[68] Byatt celebrates what Smith calls 'a woman's not-giving-a-fuckness'.[69] Ines' transformative freedom aligns with Smith's theory that, post-menopause:

> you aren't fixed in one place. You don't know. Whatever experiments you wish to undertake, whatever quest for true selfhood you embark upon, you are constantly moving, incapable of ever capturing that perfect, true, eternal self.[70]

This is denoted in Byatt's explosive ending, and the limit-breaking transformation cited by Jackson is far more significant than Rita's unassuming slip into stone, or Hermione's shame-forced petrification. The 'perfect, true, eternal self' is a mould into which the shamed women are forced, orifices stoppered and mouths closed by men. The motion and unfixed shape of Maldoror and Ines, the postmenopausal woman, beyond fertility and imbued with a freedom to pursue a 'quest for true selfhood', generate petrification that is more metamorphosis than marmorisation.

In another moment where Byatt is more overtly metatextual, Ines compares Thorsteinn to Pygmalion in her restoration of crumbling grave statues. He says:

> "I am not supposed to appropriate things that belong here. But I take the lost ones – I look for the life in them."
>
> "Pygmalion."
>
> "Hardly. You like them?"
>
> "Like is the wrong word. They are alive."[71]

Thorsteinn indicates his stone carving uncovers what is already inherent within the stone, exactly as Pygmalion does. Ovid tries to make his story about love rather than pure carnal desire. Venus' intervention, bringing Pygmalion's carved creation to life, 'leaves it ambiguous whether Pygmalion is a lucky fool or a creative genius'.[72] Byatt invites us to analogise Thorsteinn and Ines to the *Pygmalion* myth by referencing it directly in their dialogue. Ines' wonder regarding her transformation never implies a desire to change back, to become human again. She is triumphant at the story's close, when she leaves Thorsteinn and dances away into the Icelandic wilds. He 'heard her laughter in the wind'[73] as she departs, described as the 'woman in his stone garden'; therefore, despite Ines' total petrification in these last few lines of the story, she is at her most grotesque and, surrounded by a stony landscape, her most human before she 'began a dancing run into the blizzard'.[74] Told in the perspective of close third person, we sit inside Ines' thoughts as the story unfolds – this contrast with male antagonism is a significant thread within the work. Thorsteinn does not attempt to control, change, or otherwise interfere with Ines in any way. His role might appear two-dimensional; to aid in her journey to Iceland in her new stone form. But he is *here* as a foil; within Ines' story as an example of a post-menopausal woman transforming in an autonomous and liberated way, Thorsteinn exemplifies a male presence that is

helpful, hopeful, and counteracts the fear and coercion demonstrated by male antagonists of the other texts.

Pitcher argues that *The Winter's Tale* is romance, wherein 'the dead don't die'.[75] Petrification is not always a quiet slide into transformation; it can happen in an Icelandic blizzard, or in the freezing ocean. Whilst there are unique features in the discussed female petrifications, they universally implicate men and the shaming light directed at these women. Female silencing and pain reverberate through the centuries, from Galatea to Rita. Women like Lindsay are left cornered by shaming and warped male accusations but, to echo Pitcher, *the dead don't die.* They are immortalised through the castigation of those who perpetrate their shame. Suppression of the Rabelaisian grotesque body links women who, like Hermione, Rita, and Galatea, are subjected to an oppressive male gaze, whether idolising or shaming, and which results in their transformation. All these transforming women have transcended their physical bodies to become *other*; Charles Segal writes that the 'body is the constant reminder of our creatureliness, our kinship with other living, and dying beings'[76] – the significance of petrification is that the women prior to Ines, who have not experienced the menopause, are metamorphosised through dangerous male attention. They are no longer Bakhtinian creatures, but have been transformed into aesthetic objects, transcending the disgusting grotesqueness of womanhood, and moving into the sphere of objecthood. Margaret Atwood's quote, often condensed to 'men are afraid that women will laugh at them; women are afraid that men will kill them',[77] emphasises both that the man, to protect his pride and avoid becoming an object of shame himself, bounces it back to the woman. Then, like the basilisk's, this focused stare petrifies her. She eschews the human oozing body and armours herself in protective stone, or sealed, therefore neutralised and silenced by men who are truly, deeply afraid and whose only recourse is control. A Classical body, stony and silent, is much more manageable. Rabelais' grotesque, the material bodily principle, is linked to his Carnivalesque, significantly to 'carnival laughter […] a festive laughter. […] this laughter is ambivalent: it is gay, triumphant, and at the same time mocking, deriding'.[78] In short, this is exactly the kind of laughter pealing from the aforementioned cankerous female mouths that the insecure male perpetrators are trying to stop and that Thorsteinn encourages and facilitates. With lava-like blood coursing through her veins, Ines' story culminates with female laughter, exaggerating her transition into a grotesque form, her natural, earthy body, and simultaneously defies any potential men who would try to seal and silence it.

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